enquired about the standard of rations. Practically during every conference, I would make it a point to convey to my army commanders and principal staff officers that they must ensure that all ranks get their authorized rations and of the specified quality. I believed that the specifications needed to be upscaled if we wanted to see a genuine improvement. In fact, we began sending the feedback received from the lower formations for the information of the defence minister. One day, I asked for a meeting with the minister wherein a presentation would be made about the need to enhance the qualitative specifications of rations. I ensured the presence of the secretaries of defence and finance so that we could get an approval in principle on the spot, and move the file thereafter. I am grateful to the minister that he approved our proposals, and today the armed forces are getting a much better quality of basic rations (rice, wheat, lentils, tea, salt and sugar). We received a complaint from the ministry of defence against the head of supplies relating to some irregularities in procurement of rations. This matter was investigated and as a result, some of the individuals found blameworthy are now facing a court martial or other disciplinary action.

As mentioned earlier, one of my foremost key result areas was the health care of our serving and retired soldiers. It was projected to the ministry of defence that we needed the latest equipment and diagnostic facilities – as are available at the Research and Referral Hospital in Delhi – at all our command hospitals, namely at Udhampur, Chandigarh, Pune, Calcutta, Lucknow and Guwahati. This process started in 2006–07. I won't be amiss in stating that the armed forces medical, dental, nursing officers and paramedics are amongst the best in the country; some of them are indeed world class. All they need is state-of-the-art facilities and equipment. And this received my undivided attention. It was also my desire that the Ex-Servicemen Contributory Health Scheme (ECHS) emerges as the best health care project for our veterans. Even though the Army HQ launched this scheme a bit prematurely in 2004–05, as the army commander, Western Command, I ordered the deployment of doctors and paramedic staff along with equipment of our combat